

CHAPTER 15

FOUR LIES AND A TRUTH: TESTING THE LIE DETECTOR

'Can I test the machine?'

19 December 1994. This was an exciting day, I was to take the lie detector test. I had heard about this contraption that forensic experts wire to accused and ask questions. Despite being a scientist, I had no idea how it worked—till Dr Lahari, who came to test, explained it to me.

The doctor from the Central Forensic Laboratory was in his sixties. His wrinkles spoke of his experience, mostly results of frowns, I thought. He explained that it is not mandatory to take a lie detector test in India; it can be done only with the concurrence of the suspect. In the US, it was admissible evidence in a court of law; in India it was not a primary evidence.

He gave me a thorough briefing of the working of the polygraph machine. Electrodes would be connected to my index finger and to the fourth finger of both my hands, besides instruments keeping a tab on my blood pressure, pulse and other vitals.

If I tell a lie, there will be a minor change in my biochemical signals, which result in microscopic sweating of my fingers. Moisture will change the capacitance between the electrode and my finger, which will be captured by a computer and shown on a screen. This would be corroborated with variations in readings of other vital parameters. Dr Lahari said he had 'absolute faith' in the machine that has never betrayed him.

'Can I test the machine?' I asked Dr Lahari.